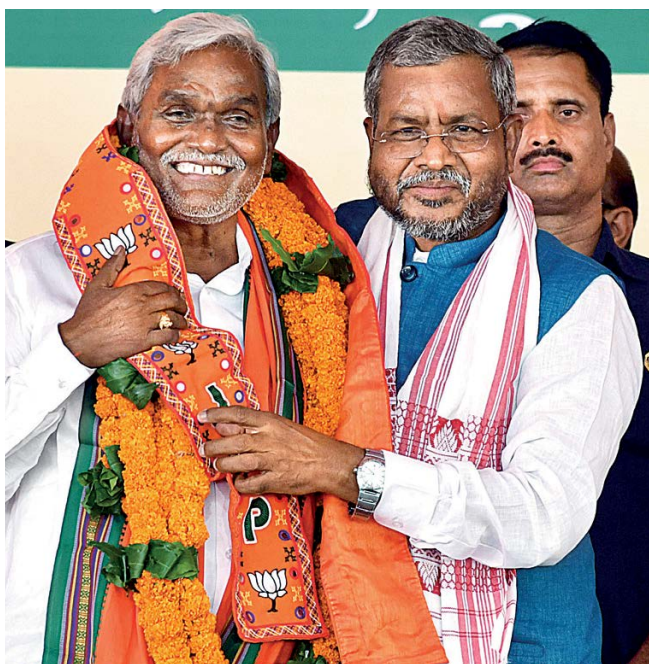
Photographs by **ANI**





COALITION SHOCK
Union minister Nitin Gadkari (second, left) with Maharashtra deputy CM Ajit Pawar, CM Eknath Shinde and deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis at a govt scheme launch, Mumbai, Aug. 31



WELCOME EMBRACE
Jharkhand BJP chief Babulal Marandi (right) felicitates ex-CM Champai Soren in Ranchi after he joins the party, Aug. 30

factions now seems like an albatross weighing down deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis of the BJP.

Fadnavis now seems caught in the crossfire over the Maratha reservation stir, one that certain quarters say was devised by Chief Minister Eknath Shinde of the Shiv Sena. The deputy CM's loyalists are also bitter at the BJP's Maratha stalwarts for not providing him cover. They point to how the ex-CM has made "sacrifices", following the central leadership's lead and demoting himself to being Shinde's deputy after the July 2022 coup. The RSS has also been firing at will, their grouse being the inclusion of the Ajit Pawar faction of the NCP in the Mahayuti fold. In June, Sangh ideologue Ratan Sharda even wrote an editorial in RSS-backed magazine *Organiser*, blaming Ajit's induction for the BJP losing the 'corruption narrative'. For the record, at least five Lok Sabha candidates of the Mahayuti alliance, including Narayan Rane of the BJP, have been investigated in corruption-related cases at some point. Now, the clamour is rising within the party against such leaders being given prominence.

Meanwhile, in Haryana, the party is trying hard to consolidate the traditional voter base. Ex-CM and now Union minister Manohar Lal Khattar's shadow still looms large here. Indeed, new CM Nayab Singh Saini's big qualification had been his loyalty to Khattar. The latter's decade-long reign, though, has left behind massive anti-incumbency, and internal surveys show that former CM and Congress leader Bhupinder S. Hooda has tightened his grip, even making inroads into the BJP's traditional non-Jat vote base. The party is now focusing on social sector schemes as a last-gasp measure to retrieve ground. On September 4, the BJP came out with its first list of 67 candidates for Haryana. At first glance, Khattar's influence seems to be on the wane—many of his loyalists were denied tickets.

Saini has made policy corrections in several flagship schemes and announced doles for the youth and women. In Maharashtra, too, CM Shinde has launched the Ladki Bahin scheme as part of which women will get Rs 1,500 per month. The scheme was a game-changer for the BJP in Madhya Pradesh in December 2023, helping it quell the anti-incumbency of two decades.

Of the three states now headed for the polls, Jharkhand had been the only bright spot for the BJP in the general election, where the party won eight out of the state's 14 seats. So far,